

Administering the GBHS Risk Factor Questionnaire

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5.1 The Risk Factor Questionnaire

The Risk Factor Questionnaire collects information about potential risk factors for breast cancer (socioeconomic status, ages at menarche and menopause, number of births, age at first birth, breastfeeding history, family history of breast cancer, history of benign breast disease, height, weight, alcohol consumption, physical activity levels, and screening history) as well as unique exposures such as malaria history, use of hair straighteners, and the use of skin lighteners. To better focus on future preventive measures for breast health, the questionnaire also assesses health care seeking behaviors, including visits to non-traditional practitioners and reasons for delay in accessing institutional health care.

The Risk Factor Questionnaire is administered to enrolled Cases and Controls. Furthermore, the questionnaire is administered only by trained Interviewers. Administering the questionnaire takes an average of 45 to 60 minutes depending on each woman's ability to answer questions, her family history, number of pregnancies, etc.

A questionnaire in English is administered to participants who feel comfortable with this language. For women who feel more comfortable being interviewed in Twi, a Twi-language version of the questionnaire was made available for the pilot feasibility study. It was determined in the early implementation of the feasibility study that the Twi version was awkward to use as Twi is largely a spoken language rather than a written language. In December 2013, the Twi version was officially retired from use. Interviewers, then familiar with administration of the interview, were instructed to use the English Version Questionnaire and verbally translate it into Twi during the interview. A question was added to the English Version Questionnaire (Version 2.0) to capture the language of interview administration.

In January 2014, a revised version of the English Version Questionnaire (Version 2.0) replaced the first version of the questionnaire (Version 1.0). Modifications were made to the questionnaire in response to feedback from interviewers and review by NCI. An interviewer refresher training session was held in early January 2014 to discuss the changes and answer any questions from interviewers prior to implementation.

5.2 Questionnaire Sections

There are 14 sections in the questionnaire – A through N. Some are quite short while others are more extensive.

- **Section A – Background Information.** This section asks information about age, marital status, education, religion, ethnicity, and concludes with a few questions about the woman's home, such as if they have electricity, various appliances, etc.
- **Section B – Pregnancy History.** This section covers pregnancy and childbirth, a fairly sensitive topic. In addition to live births, the section asks about miscarriages and abortions.
- **Section C – Menstrual History and Menopause.** This section focuses on menstrual history and menopause.
- **Section D – Family Planning.** This is another sensitive section. It asks about birth control, also known as family planning.
- **Section E – Height and Weight.** Under this section height and weight questions are asked of the respondent.
- **Sections F – Alcohol Use.** This section asks about past and current alcohol use.
- **Section G – Tobacco Use, Respectively.** This section asks questions about use of cigarettes and smokeless tobacco.
- **Section H – Family History of Breast Cancer.** This section concerns the woman's family history and whether any female relatives ever had breast cancer.
- **Section I – Environmental Exposures.** This section gathers information on environmental exposures and also asks about skin lighteners as well as hair products.
- **Section J – Occupation.** It concerns the woman's potential exposure to chemicals and herbicides based on her or her family's occupation.
- **Section K – Health Care Utilization and Medical History.** This section asks questions about health care utilization as well as medical history.
- **Section L – Physical History Activity.** Section L addresses physical activity.
- **Section M – Supplementary Questions for Cases Enrolled in the Study.** This section will be asked only to women enrolled as a Case in the Study.
- **Section N – Quality of Interview.** This final section covers the Interviewer's observations and should be completed once the interview concludes.

5.2.1 Critical Questions

The questionnaire also has certain questions in bold type with an asterisk followed by the question number. All questions in bold are called critical questions:

Example:

★F1. Has there ever been a time in your life when you had at least one drink a month?

When a woman refuses all or parts of the questionnaire, the Interviewer is trained attempt questionnaire completion by asking the critical questions only.

5.2.2 Showcards

Each section of the questionnaire may require that the Interviewer use showcards to elicit a response. The Interviewer does not read the response choices but rather has the participant select one or more answers as needed by looking at the showcards. Each Interviewer will have a set of showcards numbered with the question requiring the use of showcards; some have words and others have drawings.

- **Showcard A4** – Question A4 asks about highest level of education completed. Respondent will choose one answer from showcard A4.
- **Showcard A6** – Question A6 asks about the region where respondent was born. The showcard lists the regions that respondent can select.
- **Showcard A7** – Question A7 asks for the region where the respondent lived most of her life. The showcard lists the regions that respondent can select.
- **Showcard A8** – Question A8 asks to what ethnic group the woman belongs.
- **Showcard E7-E9** – Questions E7, E8, and E9 all ask questions referring to body shapes. The same showcard with body shape silhouettes is used for women answering questions E7, E8, and E9.
- **Showcard J2** – Question J2 asks whether or not the respondent ever lived or worked on a farm growing various crops.
- **Showcard K12** – Question K12 asks the respondent what difficulties she experienced, if any, when seeing health care.
- **Showcard L1 & L6** - Questions L1 and L6 ask the respondent about light household tasks.

- **Showcard L2 & L7** - Questions L2 and L7 ask the respondent about heavy household tasks.
- **Showcard L3 & L8** - Questions L3 and L8 ask the respondent about carrying heavy loads.
- **Showcard L4 & L11** - Questions L4 and L11 ask the respondent about playing games and continuous movement.
- **Showcard L9** - Question L9 asks the respondent bathing or caring for children.
- **Showcard L10** - Question L9 asks the respondent bathing or caring for elders.

5.2.3 How to Record Answers in the Questionnaire

A few basic rules for recording responses to the questionnaire are:

- Use black or blue pen only to record answers.
- Write numbers or letters in the center of boxes.
- Circle answers choices only and one or more as indicated by the question.
- Words in CAPITALS (CAPS) are not read to respondents. Words in CAPS are instructions for Interviewers to follow. Words in CAPS can also be answer choices.
- Interviewers must follow skip patterns as indicated in CAPS and parenthesis (brackets) after specific answer choices or at the end of introductions.
- Corrections can be made by crossing out the incorrect answer and circling the correct answer.
- Notes should be made in the margins of the questionnaire or at the bottom of the page or as indicated by the Study Manager.

Upon completion of a questionnaire, Interviewers should check for completion and edit entries for legibility. Completed questionnaires are submitted to the Study Manager or Assistant Study Manager once all tasks are completed with a participant. Questionnaires should not be left unattended or read by anyone who has not been trained or certified by the study.